



AT THE STROKE OF THE MIDNIGHT HOUR, WHEN THE WORLD SLEEPS, INDIA WILL AWAKE TO LIFE AND FREEDOM

INDIAN INDEPENDENCE AND PARTITION (1947)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

End of empires

BEFORE

1885 The Indian National Congress (INC) is founded and campaigns for Indian rights.

1901 Australian colonies are united to form the Commonwealth of Australia.

1921 The Irish Free State (four-fifths of Ireland) gains independence from Britain.

1922 Egypt is given limited independence by Britain, but British troops remain to protect imperial interests.

AFTER

1947 The Commonwealth of Nations is formed—all former British colonies can take part.

1960 The Declaration of Decolonization asserts the rights of all peoples to self-determination.

For more than a century, India had been the crown jewel of the British Empire, but on the last stroke of midnight on August 14, 1947, it became an independent nation. In India's Constituent Assembly, Delhi, a special midnight gathering of parliament was convened. Jawaharlal Nehru, the first prime minister

of India, rose to his feet to declare India's freedom. However, this independence also opened a social and geographic wound that has yet to heal.

The new Indian state was split into two independent nation states: Muslim-majority Pakistan and Hindu-majority India. Pakistan itself was split between northwest and northeast, because both wings had a Muslim majority. Immediately, millions of Muslims trekked to West and East Pakistan (the latter now known as Bangladesh), while millions of Hindus and Sikhs headed toward the newly independent India. Thousands never reached it, and many died from malnutrition and disease. Across India there were outbreaks of sectarian violence, with Hindus and Sikhs on one side and Muslims on the other.

By 1948, as the great migration drew to a close, more than 15 million people had been uprooted, and between 1 million and 2 million were dead. India was independent and India's Muslims had their own independent state, but freedom came at a great cost.

The road to independence

The spirit of nationalism in India gained ground in the mid-19th century and was strengthened in 1885 by the formation of the Indian National Congress (INC). During World War I, expectations for greater self-governance were raised when Britain promised to deliver self-rule in return for India's contribution to the war effort. But Britain envisaged a gradual progress toward self-government, beginning with